

The Morning Briefing

POLITICS · LAW · MARKETS · GEOPOLITICS

TODAY'S LEAD

UAE invokes UN resolution after Iran strikes two more Gulf oil tankers

Sixteenth attack on ADNOC-linked shipping since February draws a formal Security Council invocation and GCC condemnation, as the Strait of Hormuz standoff threatens to pull a cautious Gulf power into direct confrontation with Tehran.

US POLITICS

Senate clears stopgap funding, 90-6, punting fight to September

The Senate passed a clean continuing resolution in the early hours of August 8 by a vote of 90-6, funding the government at current levels through December 11 and extending surface-transportation programs. The House had already passed its own version funding the government only through December 4, so the two chambers must still reconcile the bills. Both chambers are now in recess — the House returns August 31, the Senate September 14 — leaving the reconciliation fight for the first week of September.

WHY IT MATTERS

The Senate version blocks, until December 11, a contested White House-backed rule that would let political appointees rather than career agency staff sign off on federal grants — a fight over control of the bureaucracy that recess has delayed, not resolved.

CBS News — [cbsnews.com/news/senate-funding-bill-continuing-resolution-approved](https://www.cbsnews.com/news/senate-funding-bill-continuing-resolution-approved)

Progressive wing notches another primary win in Minnesota

Minnesota Lt. Gov. Peggy Flanagan won the Democratic Senate primary, the latest in a string of primary wins for the party's progressive wing over centrist rivals this cycle.

NPR — [npr.org/sections/politics](https://www.npr.org/sections/politics)

SCOTUS & JUDICIARY

New birthright citizenship order draws immediate legal fire

Five days after President Trump signed a new executive order narrowing birthright citizenship, ACLU and civil-rights lawyers returned to federal court in New Hampshire, asking Judge Joseph Laplante to clarify that the new order goes beyond the narrow foreign-diplomat exception the Supreme Court reaffirmed in its June 30 ruling in *Trump v. Barbara*.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is now the second Trump birthright-citizenship order to draw an immediate legal challenge, testing how far the administration can push right up to the edge of a ruling it technically did not win outright.

SCOTUSblog — [scotusblog.com/2026/08/the-new-birthright-citizenship-battle](https://www.scotusblog.com/2026/08/the-new-birthright-citizenship-battle)

Mail-in voting case fully briefed; tariff-refund fight escalates

The administration's emergency-docket bid to implement Trump's mail-in-voting executive order is now fully briefed — twelve states led by Alabama back the request, twenty-three states and DC oppose it — and a ruling could come at any time. Separately, the government is appealing a trade-court order requiring tariff refunds to all importers, not just those who sued, arguing it conflicts with the Court's 2025 limits on universal injunctions.

ANALYTICAL READ

Since March 2026 the Court has ruled for the Trump administration in roughly 80% of more than thirty emergency-docket applications, usually without argument or explanation — a pattern that keeps showing up regardless of the substance of the request.

SCOTUSblog — [scotusblog.com/2026/08/trump-administration-asks-scotus-to-rule-soon-on-mail-in-voting](https://www.scotusblog.com/2026/08/trump-administration-asks-scotus-to-rule-soon-on-mail-in-voting)

ISRAEL & MIDDLE EAST

UAE invokes UN resolution after renewed tanker strikes in the Strait of Hormuz

The UAE accused Iran's Revolutionary Guard of striking two more ADNOC-linked oil tankers on August 13 and 14 — the sixteenth such attack since the campaign began in February — and invoked UN Security Council Resolution 2817 on freedom of navigation. The Gulf Cooperation Council called it a “dangerous and unacceptable escalation,” and Qatar expli-

citly rejected using the strait as a bargaining chip. Fifteen ADNOC vessels have been hit since February, killing one crew member and injuring 20 others.

ANALYTICAL READ

This pattern — a Gulf state that has carefully avoided confronting Tehran now getting drawn into direct retaliation — looks less like Iranian recklessness than a calculated pressure campaign aimed at Washington's Gulf partners, with the costs

of February's US-Israeli strikes on Iran now falling on third parties rather than on Washington or Jerusalem. Iran's parliament is separately weighing a plan to ban US-, Israeli-, and other "hostile"-linked shipping from the strait until it is compensated for war damage — treating an international waterway as leverage rather than as a shared asset.

Foreign Affairs Forum — faf.ae/home/2026/8/14/hormuz-to-taiwan-the-geopolitics-of-chokepoints-in-a-fracturing-global-order

Netanyahu rejects Trump's 15-point Gaza plan, demands full Hamas disarmament first

Prime Minister Netanyahu rejected President Trump's 15-point Gaza peace plan, saying Israeli forces will not withdraw until Hamas is "genuinely disarmed" — a rebuff that comes just over a week after Trump announced his Board of Peace had reached a "historic" disarmament agreement with Hamas. Israel still controls roughly 70% of Gaza, according to Palestinian officials and aid agencies, and the Board of Peace itself already sided with Netanyahu on August 3, saying forces would not withdraw past the Yellow Line until full disarmament.

ANALYTICAL READ

Netanyahu's public defiance lands less than three months before Israel's October 27 election, with polls showing his coalition's majority at risk — his negotiating posture reads as much as domestic survival strategy as security policy, and Washington's own peace body bent toward his position rather than the reverse, undercutting Trump's stated frustration with him.

NPR — npr.org/2026/08/09/nx-s1-5926459/netanyahu-rejects-trump-gaza-peace-plan-israel-hamas

Weekend strikes kill at least 26 in Gaza

Israeli strikes over the weekend killed at least 26 people in Gaza, including a police official in Gaza City, according to the local Health Ministry.

NOTE

Casualty figures are sourced to Gaza's Health Ministry, one party to the conflict, and should be read as such rather than as an independently verified count.

Al Jazeera — aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/9/israel-rejects-trumps-15-point-plan-for-gaza

WORLD

Russia reportedly sharing submarine-quieting tech with China as Taiwan drills grow sharper

A retired U.S. rear admiral says Russia is transferring submarine-quieting technology to China, eroding a longstanding American undersea-detection edge amid rising Taiwan Strait tensions; China has separately supplied roughly 70% of the machine tools and 90% of the legacy chips that let Russia rebuild its defense industrial base during the Ukraine war. President Trump said he takes Beijing's and Moscow's denials of arming Iran at face value. Washington also announced

tariffs of up to 100% on Chinese drones as Taiwan ran unusually realistic blockade-survival drills during this year's Han Kuang exercises.

WHY IT MATTERS

The technology-for-industrial-base exchange between Moscow and Beijing looks like a more durable strategic realignment than either government's public statements about Iran, and Trump's public deference to those denials sits oddly next to the pattern of deepening China-Russia military cooperation.

FDD / Fox News — fdd.org/in_the_news/2026/08/12/russia-is-helping-china-close-gap-with-u-s-forces-amid-taiwan-tensions

FINANCIALS

AAPL (Apple Inc.) — \$305.93, +0.22% today. *Upper half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 68%. Analyst avg. target upside: +9.17%.

LMT (Lockheed Martin Corp) — \$608.68, +1.78% today. *Upper half of 52-week range.* 52-wk range position: 67%. Analyst avg. target upside: +2.29%.

BLK (BlackRock Inc.) — \$995.60, -2.09% today. *Trading near 52-week lows; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 26%. Analyst avg. target upside: +24.76%.

XOM (Exxon Mobil Corp) — \$146.60, -2.67% today. *Upper half of 52-week range; Street sees meaningful upside to target.* 52-wk range position: 58%. Analyst avg. target upside: +17.46%.

BTC-USD (Bitcoin) — \$62,950, -0.12% today. *Consolidating.*

XAU (Gold (spot)) — \$4,376.07, +0.45% today. *Holding steady.*

MARKET PREDICTIONS & MOVES

No dominant cross-asset signal today — moves look idiosyncratic, not macro-driven.

Lockheed's move outpacing the broader tape lines up with the day's defense/security headlines — geopolitical risk premium building into defense names.

Informational market commentary compiled 2026-08-16, not personalized financial advice.

Financials module — compiled from Google Finance quote data, 2026-08-16

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Hormuz to Taiwan: the geopolitics of chokepoints in a fracturing global order

Dr. Antonio Bhardwaj, Foreign Affairs Forum, August 14, 2026. Argues that today's overlapping crises — Hormuz, the Black Sea, Taiwan, and the tariff fight over drones — are not isolated stories but symptoms of a shift from great-power

military parity toward competition over chokepoints, critical minerals, and supply chains. Directly ties together nearly everything in today's World and Israel/Middle East coverage.

Foreign Affairs Forum — faf.ae/home/2026/8/14/hormuz-to-taiwan-the-geopolitics-of-chokepoints-in-a-fracturing-global-order

The Supreme Court shadow docket comes into the light

Alicia Bannon & Ashleigh Maciolek, Brennan Center for Justice, April 24, 2026. Leaked internal memos from 2016 show Chief Justice Roberts applying an “irreparable harm” standard to block the Obama administration's Clean Power

Plan that the Court has since abandoned when ruling for the Trump administration on the emergency docket — the same double standard driving today's mail-in-voting and birthright-citizenship fights.

Brennan Center for Justice — brennancenter.org/our-work/analysis-opinion/supreme-court-shadow-docket-comes-light